Netanyahu will not dismiss Gallant “for the time being,” which means that he will not dismiss him at all. Officially, it is because of the security situation; in reality, to hide the fact that, under pressure, he changed his mind. Netanyahu and Gallant went together to visit the Tel Nof Airbase, where Netanyahu praised the air force chief for taking a tough attitude toward those reserve pilots who had refused to report for call-ups.

The chairman of the Bank of Israel announced that according to the bank’s forecasts, in the best of cases, the financial losses due to the overhaul would be about 14 billion shekels per year for three years, in the worst of cases, 48 billion shekels. An official of the bank warned: “red light for the shekel.”

It is time for a comic interlude. Ben-Gvir appeared at the Supreme Court to defend himself against a complaint that he, a notorious racist, had been appointed minister of national security. Ben-Gvir, who fends for himself, admitted that he had been a racist when he was fourteen and had made mistakes in the past; he argued that although he had not changed his opinions, he had become more sensitive since he joined the government. The judge then asked him whether he had reached the utmost point in sensitivity, or whether he still had a bit of a road to travel.

I must admit that I look less and less for the comic aspects of a situation that, notwithstanding the conciliation talks, does not bode well. The coalition will not give in and, in a few weeks or less, it will push the overhaul through the Knesset and then all hell will break loose, leading God knows where. I fear the explosive potential of social resentment among the Mizrahim. It is in Israel that this particular wound has festered, as a result of the conditions under which the immigration from North Africa took place.

I realized this, with particular clarity, in 1966, when I was invited to teach at the French University of Montreal and rented an apartment from a Jewish Moroccan family with whom I quickly became very friendly.